

Common Medical Tests

By **The Manual's Editorial Staff**

Reviewed/Revised Feb 2025

A large number of medical tests are widely available. Many tests are used for a particular disorder or group of related disorders. Other tests are commonly used for a wide range of disorders.

Tests are done for a variety of reasons, including

- Screening
- Diagnosing a disorder
- Evaluating the severity of a disorder so that treatment can be planned
- Monitoring the response to treatment

Sometimes a test is used for more than one purpose. A blood test may show that a person has too few red blood cells (anemia). The same test may be repeated after treatment to determine whether the number of red blood cells has returned to normal. Sometimes a disorder can be treated at the same time a screening or diagnostic test is done. For example, when colonoscopy (examination of the inside of the large intestine with a flexible viewing tube) detects growths (polyps), they can be removed before colonoscopy is completed.



Some Diagnostic Procedures

Procedure	Body Area or Sample Tested	Description
Amniocentesis	Fluid from the sac surrounding the fetus	Analysis of fluid, removed by a needle inserted through the abdominal wall, to detect an abnormality in the fetus
Arteriography (angiography)	Any artery in the body, commonly in the brain, heart, kidneys, aorta, or legs	X-ray study using dye injected through a thin tube (catheter), which is threaded to the artery being studied, to detect and outline or highlight a blockage or defect in an artery
Audiometry	Ears	Assessment of the ability to hear and distinguish sounds at specific pitches and volumes using headphones
Auscultation	Heart	Listening with a stethoscope for abnormal heart sounds
Barium X-ray studies	Esophagus, stomach, intestines, or rectum	X-ray study to detect ulcers, tumors, or other abnormalities
Biopsy	Any tissue in the body	Removal and examination of a tissue sample under a microscope to check for cancer or another abnormality



MSD

Copyright © 2026 Merck & Co., Inc., Rahway, NJ, USA and its affiliates. All rights reserved.